Who Frosted My Tree?

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Saltbush Story House

For everyone who has waited
all year for the first snow.

Who Frosted My Tree?
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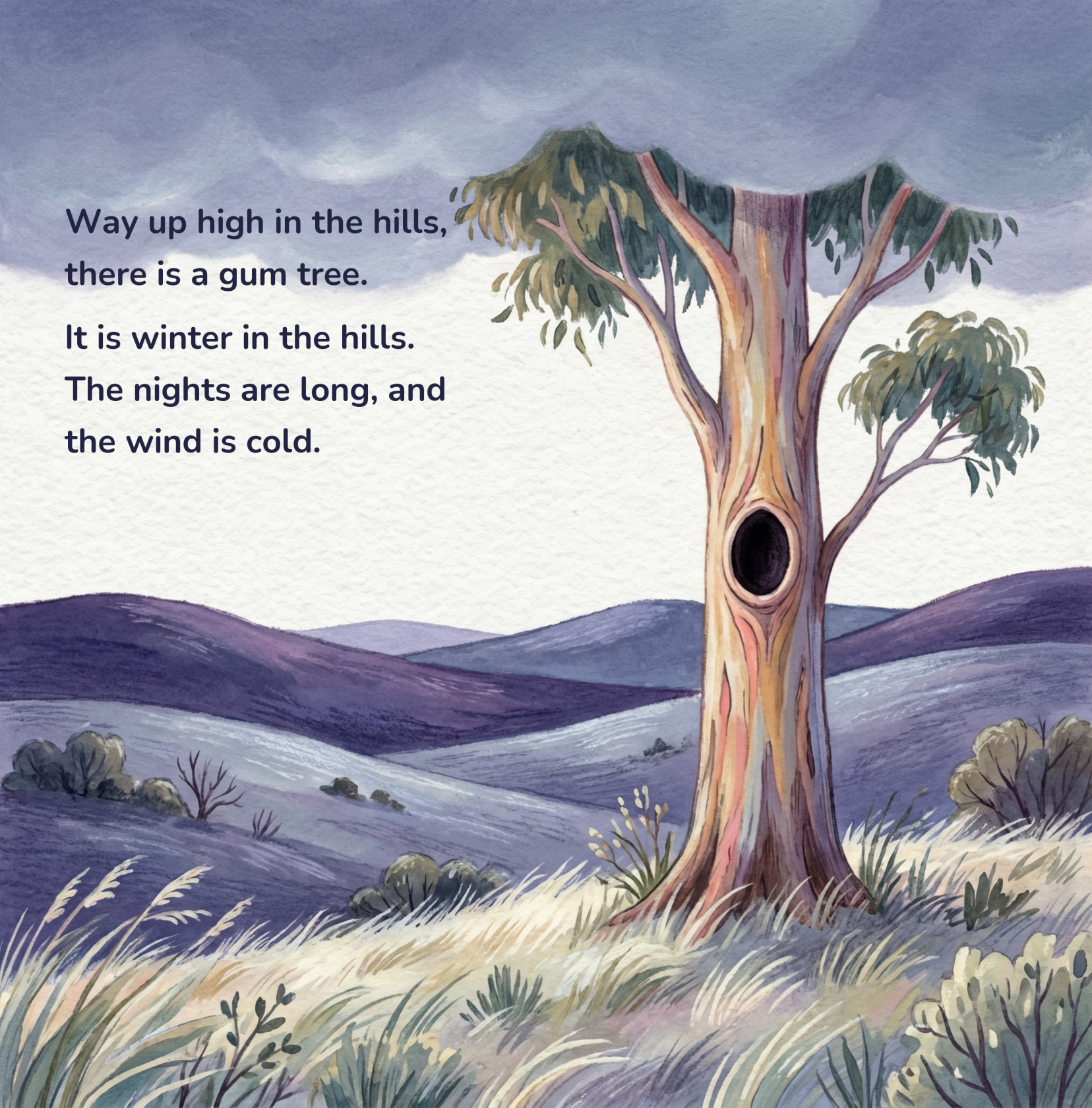
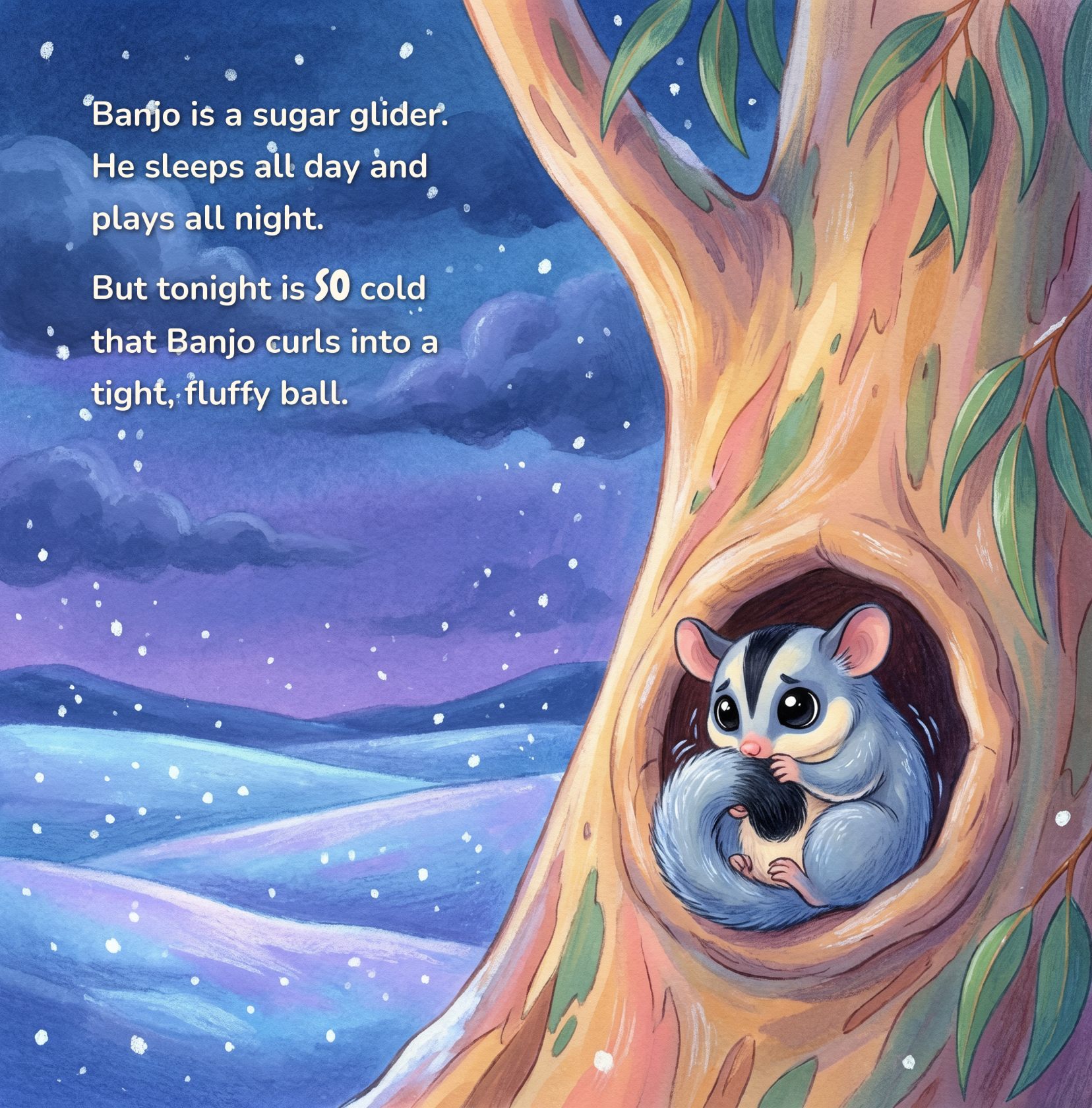


Way up high in the hills,
there is a gum tree.

It is winter in the hills.
The nights are long, and
the wind is cold.


Banjo is a sugar glider. He sleeps all day and plays all night.
But tonight is SO cold that Banjo curls into a tight, fluffy ball.

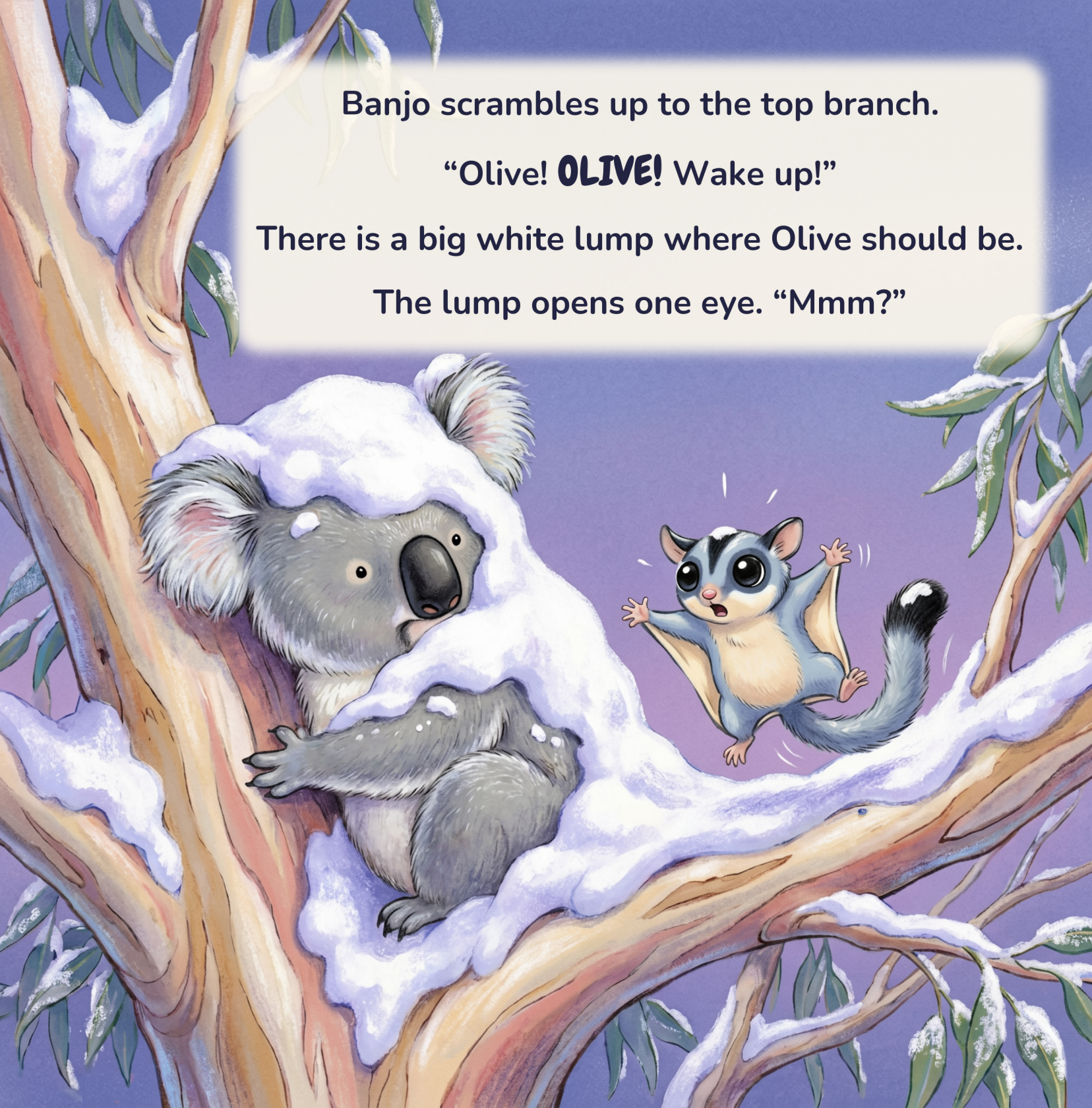
He sleeps all night.

And all day.

And all night **AGAIN**.

When Banjo finally pokes his nose out, he can’t believe his eyes.

HEY!
Somebody has FROSTED my tree!
Like a CAKE!



Banjo scrambles up to the top branch.

"Olive! **OLIVE!** Wake up!"

There is a big white lump where Olive should be.

The lump opens one eye. "Mmm?"

“It’s snow, Banjo,” says Olive.

“Snow doesn’t happen **HERE**,” says Banjo.

“Not often,” says Olive. And she closes her eye again.

“Then somebody **DID** this,” says Banjo. “And I’m going to find out who.”

Cockatoo is white. White feathers. White tail. White EVERYTHING.
Very suspicious.
“Cockatoo! Is all this white stuff YOURS?”

SQUAWK!

“My feathers are **ON** me! All of them! Count them if you like!”

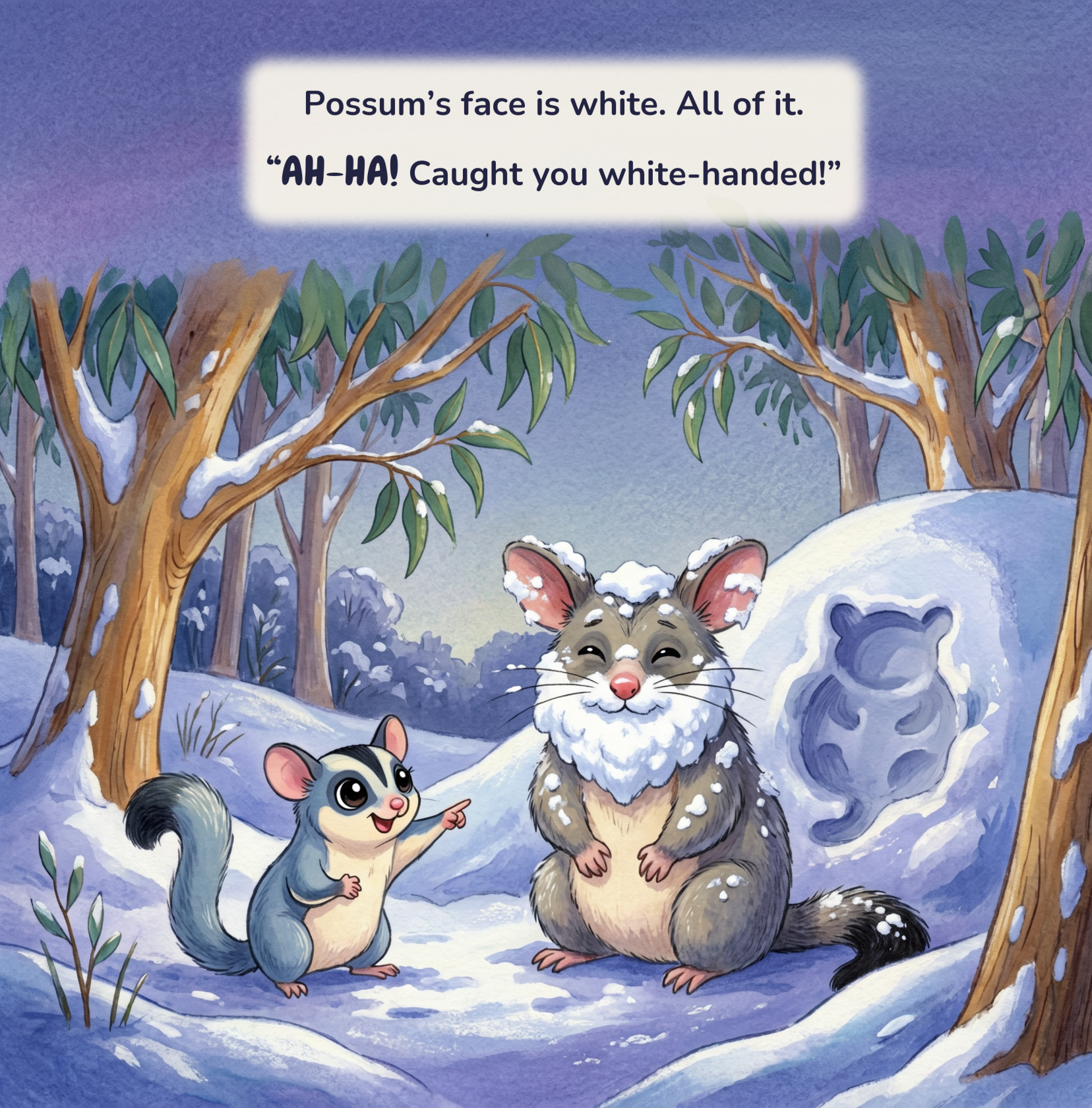
Banjo counts to eleven and gives up.

“Sorry, Cockatoo.”

More white is falling from the sky.
Banjo catches a piece.
It sparkles. It tickles. And then it's GONE.

“Disappearing frosting,” says Banjo.

“This is serious. This needs a detective.”

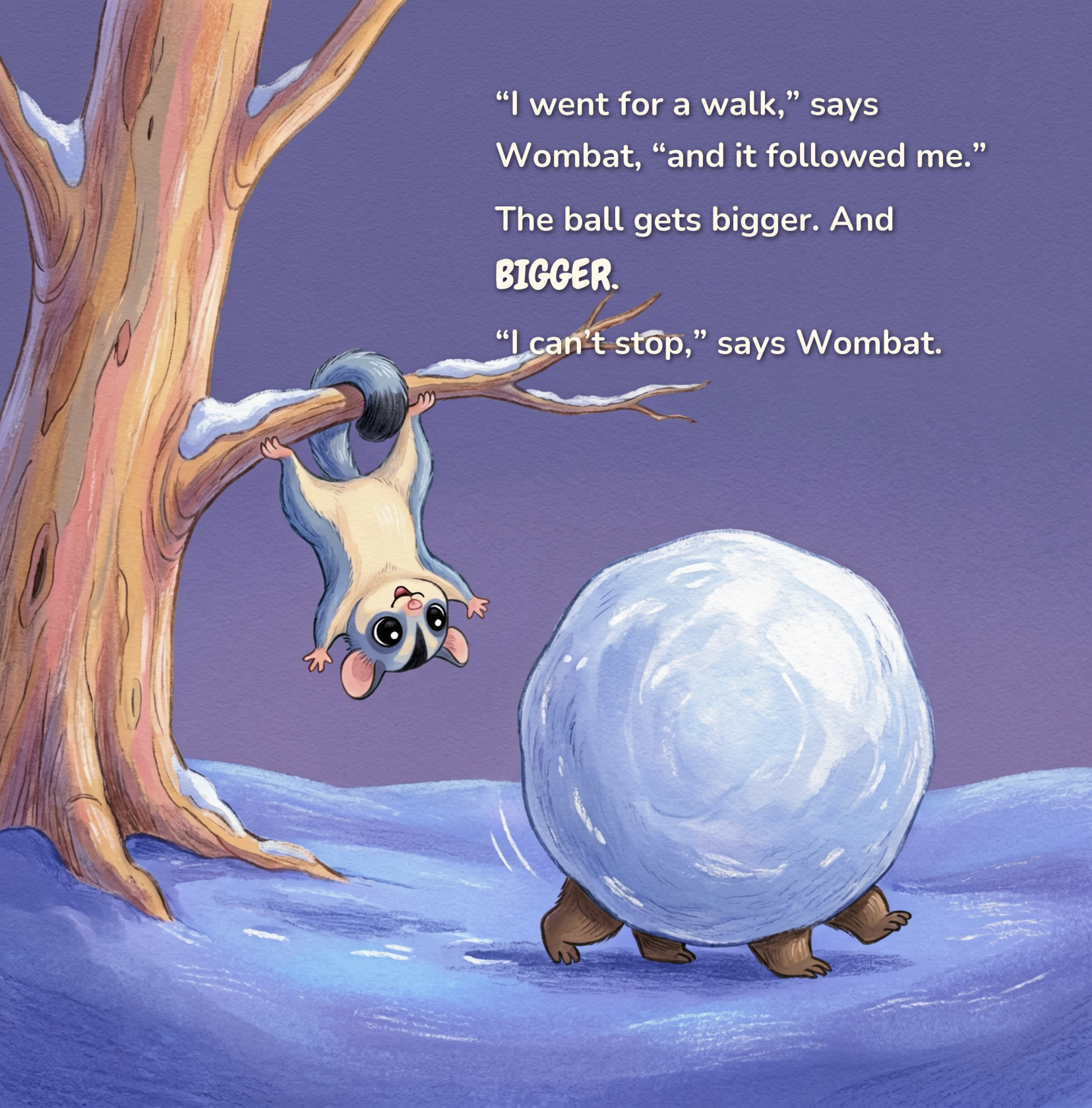

Possum's face is white. All of it.
"AH-HA! Caught you white-handed!"

“I fell in it,” says Possum. “Face first.”

“Once?”

“Twice,” says Possum. “Maybe three times.”

Then Wombat comes trundling by, pushing a giant white ball.
“Wombat! What is THAT?”


“I went for a walk,” says Wombat, “and it followed me.”
The ball gets bigger. And BIGGER.
“I can’t stop,” says Wombat.

Banjo knows who will help.
Echidna lives by the old log.
But the log is covered in snow.
And Echidna is GONE.

“Somebody took Echidna!” cries Banjo.

“Somebody frosted my tree **AND** took my friend!”

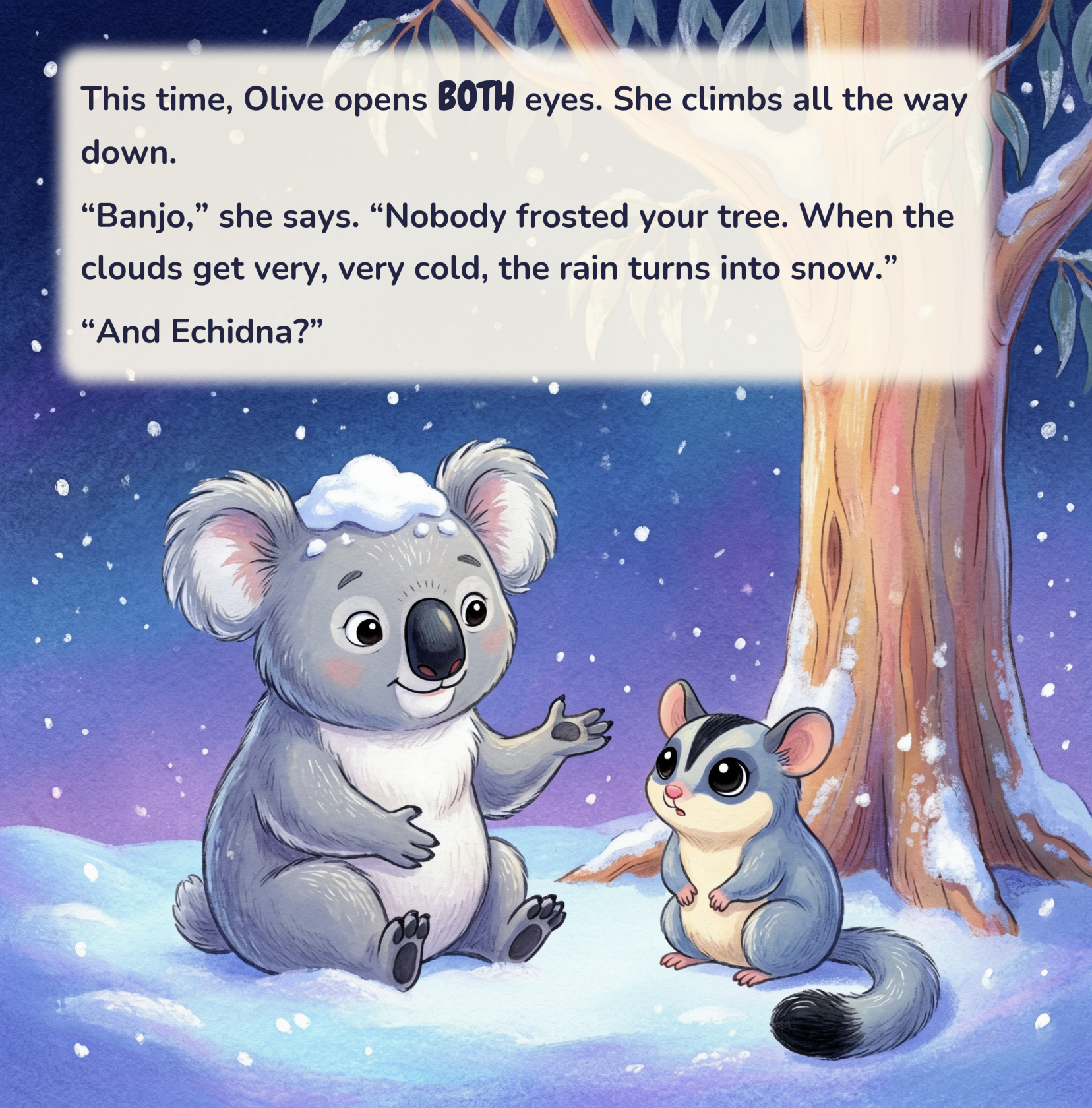
The bush is white and quiet.
No crunch. No chirp. No Echidna.

"My tree is frosted," whispers Banjo. "My friend is missing. And my toes are **FROZEN**."

This time, Olive opens **BOTH** eyes. She climbs all the way down.

“Banjo,” she says. “Nobody frosted your tree. When the clouds get very, very cold, the rain turns into snow.”

“And Echidna?”



Olive points to a small spiky bump in the snow. Under the bump, something is snoring.

“Echidna is hibernating,” says Olive. “She’s sleeping through the cold. She’ll wake up when it’s warm again.”

“She’s not missing,” says Banjo. “She’s just **VERY** asleep.”

Banjo says sorry to Cockatoo, Possum and Wombat.

And the snow? Everybody finds a use for it.

Cockatoo makes snow angels.

Possum makes a snow possum.

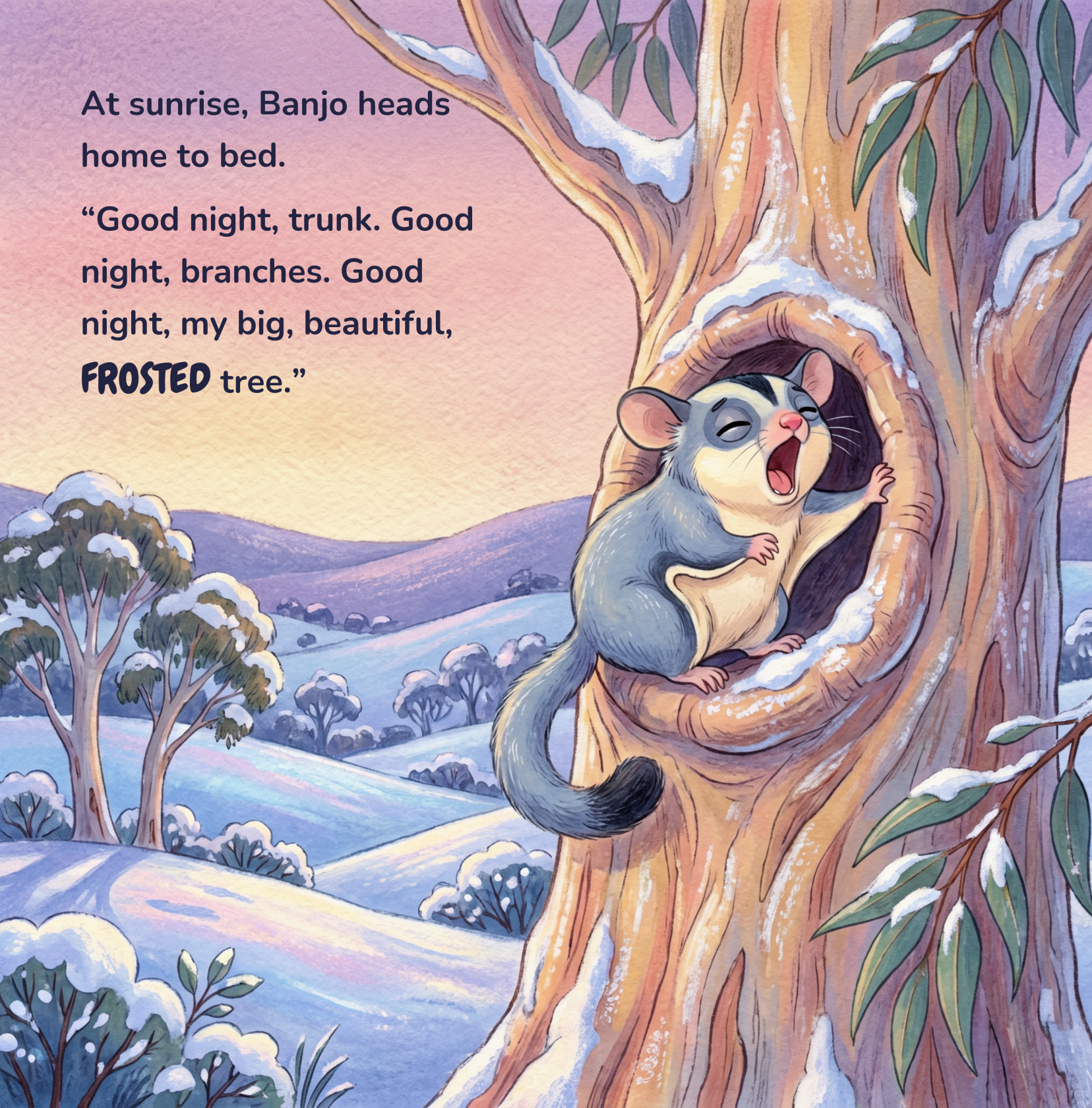
Wombat’s ball gets a gum-nut nose.

And Echidna gets the coziest blanket in the bush.

But Banjo finds the best thing of all.

Gliding through the snowflakes is the swooshiest, sparkliest, **FROSTIEST** glide in the whole bush!

WHEEE!



At sunrise, Banjo heads home to bed.

“Good night, trunk. Good night, branches. Good night, my big, beautiful, **FROSTED** tree.”

A lump of snow slides off a branch. **FLUMP!** Right on top of Olive.

"**OLIVE!** Somebody frosted **YOU!**"

"Zzz," says Olive. "Wake me up in spring."

True Facts from the Bush

Australia gets snow. Snow falls every winter in the Australian Alps, and now and then on hills and high plains further down.

Snow gums are gum trees that grow high in the snowy mountains. Their bark peels into stripes of white, gray, green, orange and red.

Snowflakes form when water freezes high in cold clouds. Most snowflakes have six sides.

Echidnas hibernate. In the coldest places, an echidna can sleep through winter for months. Its body cools right down and its heart beats very slowly.

Mountain pygmy possums hibernate under the snow in the Australian Alps for up to seven months.

Sugar gliders curl up together in their tree hollows to keep warm. On very cold nights they can drop into a deep sleep called torpor, and save energy.

Koalas have thick, woolly fur that keeps out cold and rain.

Wombats stay warm in deep burrows under the ground.

Cockatoos fluff up their feathers to trap warm air.

About the Author

Hattie Moss writes funny picture books about Australian animals. She thinks gum trees are the best trees and sugar gliders are the best gliders.

Look out for more Banjo and Olive stories, starting with *Who Peeled My Tree?*